



The rules every proposal is judged against

The CEA link for the December 2026 timetable — the one set of rules all 26 proposal sheets are measured against

Prepared 28 September 2026 · the rules and every figure below are read from the same code that writes the proposal sheets, not typed

HARD LIMITS

A design must meet these or it cannot be run.
Three of them.

DECEMBER 2026 RULES

The staffing the station has asked for. Eleven of them, each met or not. Weigh them against each other.

FATIGUE FACTORS

Patterns that tend to tire people. Advisory only: “present” means worth a look, never a breach.

The basics every rule assumes

Opening hours. The station opens at 06:20 (07:15 on a Sunday) and closes at 23:55 (23:25 on a Sunday).

Cover week. A line with no fixed shifts: four duties in the week, placed by the roster clerk to cover leave and sickness.

The floor. Everyone on duty except the four ticket-office staff, who are there for the office's opening hours, not the trains. One of each ticket-office pair helps on the floor at the quiet ends: the morning one until 08:00 (09:00 on a Sunday), the evening one from 19:30; on a Sunday evening they split their time, counted as half a person.

The link. 24 lines worked in turn, one week each, Sunday to Saturday; a person on the last line moves to line 1.

Early and late. A shift starting before 11:00 is an early; from 11:00 it is a late.

Today's link. The 20-line link worked now. It is the yardstick, not the target: it meets 4 of the 11 December rules.

Hard limits **MUST BE MET**

LIMIT	WHAT IT MEANS	TODAY'S LINK	MET BY
At least 12 hours between duties	From the end of one duty to the start of the next, anywhere in the rotation — Saturday into Sunday, and the last line into line 1, included.	✓ shortest 12h 30m	25 of 26
No more than 13 days worked in a row	Chiltern's limit, taken at its worst case: a cover week's four duties placed as badly as they can be. The written source of the 13-day limit is still to be confirmed.	✓ longest 9 days	26 of 26
The contracted week, exactly	35 hours a week on average, Monday to Saturday, across all 24 lines; a cover week counts as a contracted week. Sunday duties are paid on top as rest-day working, as they are today. Individual weeks may be longer or shorter; only the average is the contract.	✓ exactly 35h	25 of 26

The December 2026 rules **MET OR NOT**

Every number is a **minimum**: too few is the problem, never too many. The staffing levels were given verbally and are not yet in writing. **3 proposals meet all eleven** (Familiar Nine, Just Enough and Right Away).

RULE	WHAT IT ASKS, EXACTLY	TODAY'S LINK	MET BY
At least four on at the open, every day	Four people on duty from the moment the station opens: 06:20, or 07:15 on a Sunday.	× 4 · 4 · 3	13 of 26
At least three through to the close, every day	Three people still on duty until the station closes: 23:55, or 23:25 on a Sunday.	× 2 · 2 · 3	26 of 26
At least five still on duty at 22:00, every day	Five people still on duty at 22:00. Only people working <i>after</i> 22:00 count; someone finishing at 22:00 does not.	× 4 · 2 · 3	5 of 26
Fourteen on a Saturday, ten on a Sunday	Fourteen people working on a Saturday and ten on a Sunday, counted as duties rostered that day.	× 10 · 8	11 of 26
Four cover weeks, evenly spread	Four cover weeks in the 24 lines, spaced evenly — every six lines, e.g. lines 1, 7, 13 and 19.	× lines 1, 7, 12, 17	13 of 26
The ticket office: two early and two late, identical shifts, every day	Two identical early and two identical late shifts for the ticket office: Mon–Fri 06:20–14:20 and 14:00–22:30; Sat 06:20–14:50 and 14:30–22:00; Sun two starting 07:15 and two finishing 22:30.	× Mon–Fri yes · Sat yes · Sun no	3 of 26
Every weekday closer starts at 15:45	Every Monday-to-Friday shift that works to the 23:55 close starts at 15:45.	× closers start at 15:15	7 of 26
At least two on the floor at every moment	At least two people on the station floor at every moment the station is open, checked every five minutes. Ticket-office staff count only while the second of a pair helps on the floor at the quiet ends, and only as a whole person.	✓ fewest 2 · 2 · 2	3 of 26
Handovers: 15 minutes to each closer, 20 in the ticket office	Each closer overlaps someone already on duty by 15 minutes; the two ticket-office shifts overlap by 20. On a Sunday each opener also stays until 15 minutes after the last closer arrives.	✓ floor met · ticket office 20 min	22 of 26
Sunday duties between 8h and 9h	Every Sunday duty is between 8 and 9 hours long.	✓ 8h 00m–8h 55m	22 of 26
No more shift times than today	No more different shift times in the week than today's link has (18).	✓ 18	12 of 26

Today's figures read Mon–Fri · Saturday · Sunday; a range means the weekdays differ. “Met by” counts the 26 proposal sheets in the folder.

Fatigue factors, preferences, and what is still open

The advisory list, what is for staff to say rather than the rules, and the questions not yet settled

Fatigue factors ADVISORY

25 roster patterns that tend to tire people: 21 from the Office of Rail and Road's good-practice guidance, *Fatigue Factors* (page 3, December 2021), and 4 extra checks from the rail industry's fatigue guidance (MRSF). The ORR says they are guidance, not limits. So a factor present is a question to discuss, never a pass or a fail, and a design showing none is not thereby approved.

CODE	FACTOR	KIND	PRESENT IN
FF2	Early shift starting 05:00–07:00	Time of day	Every design
FF3	Very early shift starting before 05:00	Time of day	0
FF5	Day shift over 12h	Duty length	0
FF7	Early shift over 10h	Duty length	0
FF8b	Fewer than 2 days rest after a block of early starts	Recovery time	12
FF11	More than 13 consecutive shifts without a 48h break	Recovery time	6
FF10	More than 4 consecutive 12h day shifts	Cumulative	0
FF15	More than 4 consecutive early shifts in a rotating pattern	Cumulative	10
MRSF	More than 12 consecutive day shifts	Cumulative	0
MRSF	More than 55 hours worked in any 7-day period	Cumulative	4
MRSF	More than 7 consecutive 8h shifts	Cumulative	1
FF17	Backward rotating pattern	Circadian	0
FF18	Rotating pattern of about a week	Circadian	Every design
FF19	Successive start times varying by more than 2 hours definition to confirm	Circadian	18
FF13	Less than 12h rest in any 24h	Intervals between duties	1

Not applicable. 10 more factors apply to no rotation here: 8 about night shifts (FF1, FF6, FF8, FF9, FF12, FF14, FF16 and FF20), because CEAs do not work nights; FF4, because no shift starts before 05:00; and the MRSF permanent-pattern check, because the link rotates (FF15 is its rotating equivalent). **"Every design"** marks a standing factor — one that comes with the station's hours or with any weekly link, not with a design's choices: FF2 because the station opens at 06:20, and FF18 because a weekly link changes shift type about once a week (the ORR prefers two-day or three-week rotation, *Managing rail staff fatigue* 7.68). **Standing factors are recorded on every sheet for information and are not counted** in any design's fatigue findings, since no weekly design can remove them. The **early** in FF2 and FF15 is the ORR's — a start from 05:00 to 07:00 — not the 11:00 used everywhere else. "Present in" counts the 26 proposals.

Preferences FOR STAFF TO SAY, NOT THE APP

- **Days in a row.** The Links designer aims for six or fewer, well inside the 13-day limit.
- **Full weekends off** — a Saturday off followed by a Sunday off at the start of the next line. Today's link gives 4 in 20.
- **Weeks on one shift time** — the same clock time Monday to Friday, all earlies or all lates. A week that mixes the two is what people mean by "all over the place".
- **Familiar shift times** — how many of a design's times somebody already works today. A rough guide to what there is to learn, not to what staff will accept.
- **Following the trains** — how closely the floor's staffing follows the December 2026 timetable, hour by hour. A guide, and one way of measuring it among several.

Still to settle

1. **Does someone finishing at 22:00 count as "still on duty at 22:00"?** Today they do not. Counting them would change the 22:00 rule on many designs, because a lot of late turns end at 22:00.
2. **Does the 22:00 rule apply on a Sunday?** Today it is checked every day.
3. **The source of the 13-day limit.** Somebody confirms where it is written down.
4. **The December 2026 staffing levels in writing.** The eleven rules were given verbally.
5. **One fatigue definition to confirm.** FF19 is counted on a reading an assessing manager should confirm: FF19 treats a rest day as time to adjust, where the ORR's wording ("consecutive duties") would count across rest days — and on that reading every link has it.
6. **Sunday's finish.** 5 trains in the December 2026 timetable arrive or leave after the 23:25 Sunday close, the last at 23:54. Should Sunday cover run later?

Changing a rule. Every proposal sheet is checked against this set by the same code. Change a rule and all 26 sheets and this page are re-rendered together, so no sheet is ever judged against an older version of it.